

Abu Simbel Temples

Ancient temples that are a tribute to the power and authority of ancient Egypt



The two spectacular cliff-cut temples of Abu Simbel are among the most famous of Egypt's ancient monuments. Situated on the west bank of the River Nile in the south of the country, the colossal structures were commissioned by Ramesses II, whose reign (c.1279–1213 BCE) was the longest in Egyptian imperial history.

An astute statesman, the pharaoh built the two sandstone temples as symbols of his power and the might of his kingdom. The date when construction began is the subject of debate, but the temples are thought to have taken 20 years to build. Ramesses dedicated the main temple, or the Great Temple, to himself and a smaller temple, the Small Temple, to his principal wife, Queen Nefertari, the personification of the goddess Hathor.

Symbols of power

The Great Temple is a huge edifice, 108 ft (33 m) high, with an imposing facade: two pairs of massive statues, 66 ft (20 m) high, of the enthroned Ramesses flank the

entrance. The interior of the temple is triangular in layout and includes various chambers and three halls of decreasing size, which extend around 184 ft (56 m) into the cliff. The most breathtaking is the hypostyle hall, 30 ft (9 m) high, with its mighty pillars depicting Ramesses. Carved reliefs on the walls narrate events in the pharaoh's reign.

The Small Temple (39 ft/12 m high), immediately north of the Great Temple, has two statues of Ramesses and one of Nefertari on each side of its entrance. The temple interior is notable for its own hypostyle hall, with its six decorated pillars and walls that include images of Hathor and of the king and queen making offerings to various deities.

The UNESCO World Heritage Site attracted attention in the 1960s, when, under threat from flooding from the building of the Aswan High Dam, the temples were removed and reassembled further inland. The extraordinary feat of skill and engineering took around 4 years to complete.

▷ THOTH AS A BABOON

A statue, depicting the god Thoth as a baboon, was one of four that decorated the solar chapel, which formed part of the Great Temple.



The **relocation** of Abu Simbel involved cutting the site into around **16,000 huge blocks** and **reassembling** it piece by piece

SACRED ALIGNMENT

The architects and engineers involved in the complex relocation of Abu Simbel were careful to ensure that the entrance to the main temple was correctly aligned so that twice a year, the Sun's rays would continue to penetrate the structure's deep, innermost sanctuary and illuminate the face of the statue of the deified Ramesses II, just as they had done since the 13th century BCE.

